

Gym Exercise Guide

Your plain-English reference for every move in the GranFondo strength plan · built for a first-timer

You've never lifted — that's fine. This guide explains every exercise in your plan in plain language: what it is, how to do it, and what to watch for. Your whole strength program uses just **13 movements**. Learn these and you're set for all 13 weeks.

The golden rule for the first weeks: form over weight. Start light (often just your bodyweight). A movement done well with no weight beats a heavy one done badly. Ego has no place here — everyone in the gym started exactly where you are.

 **Watch one demo per exercise.** Each card below has a YouTube search — a 60-second video makes any of these click instantly. Do that once before your first session.

Gym 101 — read this first

"3 × 12" means 3 sets of 12 reps. Do 12 repetitions, rest, repeat — 3 times total.

Bodyweight = no added weight, just your body. Where most of your first weeks live.

Rest between sets: 60–120 seconds for the big leg moves; 30–45 sec for core. Don't rush.

Tempo: controlled — about 2 sec down, 1 sec up. No bouncing or dropping the weight.

When to add weight (the plan's rule): only once you complete *all* reps with perfect form two sessions in a row.

Your two gym days: Tuesday (lighter, before soccer) and **Thursday** (your main, heavier session). Same movements both days.

"each leg / each side" means that count per side (so 3×8 each leg = 16 reps a set).

Picking a weight: the last 2 reps should feel hard but doable with clean form. Too easy → go heavier next time. Form breaks → go lighter.

Breathing: breathe out on the hard part (standing up, pressing). Never hold your breath through a whole rep.

Warm up first: 5 min easy bike, then a set of each move with no weight before loading up.

Sore vs hurt: muscle burn and next-day soreness are normal. Sharp joint pain is not — stop and reset your form.

Lost? Ask. Gym staff will happily show you a machine or check your form. It's literally their job.

👉 Lower body & glutes — your engine

1 Goblet Squat

LEGS · GLUTES

Equipment: one dumbbell or kettlebell

WHAT IT IS

A squat where you hold a single weight at your chest. The easiest, safest way to learn to squat well — the weight at the front actually helps you balance.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Hold a dumbbell *vertically* against your chest, both hands cupping the top end (like holding a goblet).
2. Stand with feet shoulder-width, toes turned slightly out.
3. Brace your stomach. Push your hips back and bend your knees, lowering until your thighs are about parallel to the floor.
4. Keep your chest tall and your heels flat on the ground.
5. Drive up through your heels to stand; squeeze your glutes at the top.

FORM CUES

- ✓ Knees track out over your toes — don't let them cave inward.
- ✓ Chest up, back flat, weight stays on your heels.
- ✗ Don't go deeper than you can keep your heels planted — depth comes with time.

You should feel it in your **thighs & glutes**

🔍 Search: "**goblet squat proper form**"

2 Barbell Back Squat

LEGS · GLUTES

Equipment: barbell + squat rack · *(Phase 2 upgrade from the goblet squat)*

WHAT IT IS

The classic strength squat: a barbell rests across your upper back while you squat. More load than the goblet squat, so it builds more power — but it needs a rack and good setup.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Set the bar in the rack at about collarbone height. Set the safety pins.
2. Step under and rest the bar on the meat of your upper back (the shelf of muscle — *not* your neck). Grip slightly wider than your shoulders.
3. Stand the bar up, take 1–2 steps back, feet shoulder-width.
4. Brace your stomach, push your hips back and squat to about parallel.
5. Drive up through your heels back to standing.

FORM CUES

- ✓ **Start with just the empty bar** (it weighs ~20 kg) to learn the groove. Add 5–10 kg only when reps feel solid.
- ✓ Keep the bar stacked over your mid-foot; chest up, knees pushed out.
- ✗ Don't squat heavy without the safety pins set — they let you bail safely.

You should feel it in your **thighs & glutes**

 Search: **"how to barbell back squat beginner"** · *Nervous about the rack? Keep doing goblet squats — they train the same thing.*

3 Romanian Deadlift (RDL)

HAMSTRINGS · GLUTES

Equipment: dumbbells or a barbell

WHAT IT IS

A "hip hinge" — you bend at the hips with a nearly straight back to load the *back* of your legs. Possibly the most valuable move here: it builds cycling power and a bulletproof lower back. Learn it carefully.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Hold the weights in front of your thighs, feet hip-width apart.
2. Put a soft bend in your knees — and keep that same bend the whole time (you don't squat down).
3. Push your hips *backwards* — imagine closing a car door with your butt — letting the weights slide down the front of your legs.
4. Keep your back flat and the weights grazing your legs.
5. Lower until you feel a stretch in your hamstrings (usually around your shins), then squeeze your glutes to stand tall.

FORM CUES

- ✓ This is a **hinge, not a squat** — the movement is hips going back, not knees bending down.
- ✓ Back stays flat the entire time; weights stay close to your legs.
- ✗ Don't round your back or reach for the floor — stop when your hamstrings say stop.

You should feel it in your **hamstrings & glutes** (stretch, then squeeze)

 Search: **"romanian deadlift dumbbell form"**

4 Bulgarian Split Squat

SINGLE-LEG · BALANCE

Equipment: a bench · optional dumbbells (bodyweight to start)

WHAT IT IS

A single-leg squat with your back foot raised on a bench. Humbling at first, but brilliant for cyclists — it builds each leg on its own and trains balance. (Don't be surprised if bodyweight alone is plenty early on.)

HOW TO DO IT

1. Stand about two feet in front of a bench, facing away from it.
2. Rest the top of one foot behind you on the bench.
3. Keep most of your weight on the *front* foot.
4. Lower straight down by bending the front knee until your front thigh is about parallel to the floor.
5. Drive up through the front heel. Finish all reps, then switch legs.

FORM CUES

- ✓ Stay tall with a slight forward lean from the hips; front knee tracks over the foot.
- ✓ Wobbling is normal at first — go slow, and hold a rack or wall for balance if needed.
- ✗ Don't add weight until the bodyweight version feels steady and controlled.

You should feel it in your **front-leg quad & glute**

 Search: "bulgarian split squat for beginners"

5 Walking Lunges

LEGS · GLUTES

Equipment: bodyweight · optional dumbbells (from wk 7)

WHAT IT IS

Stepping forward into a lunge and alternating legs as you "walk" across the floor. Builds single-leg strength with a bit of coordination.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Stand tall, feet together.
2. Take a controlled step forward with one leg.
3. Lower until both knees are about 90°, your back knee hovering just above the floor.
4. Push through your front heel and bring your back foot forward into the next step.
5. Keep alternating legs for the full set.

FORM CUES

- ✓ Step out far enough that your front knee stays stacked over your ankle, not past your toes.
- ✓ Torso upright; control the way down.
- ✗ Don't crash your back knee into the floor — tap lightly or stop just short.

You should feel it in your **quads & glutes**

 Search: "walking lunges proper form"

6 Step-Up

SINGLE-LEG · CYCLING-SPECIFIC

Equipment: a bench or sturdy box · optional dumbbells

WHAT IT IS

Stepping up onto a bench one leg at a time. It mimics a big pedal stroke, so it's about as cycling-specific as strength work gets. (This is the no-machine alternative to the single-leg press.)

HOW TO DO IT

1. Stand facing a knee-height bench.
2. Place one whole foot flat on the bench.
3. Drive through *that* foot's heel to stand all the way up on top — try not to push off the back foot.
4. Lower back down under control. Finish the set on one leg, then switch (or alternate).

FORM CUES

- ✓ Power comes from the heel of the **top** foot, not the toes of the bottom foot.
- ✓ Stand fully tall at the top; lower slowly rather than dropping.
- ✗ Don't use a bench so high that your knee climbs above your hip to start — knee-height is plenty.

You should feel it in the **stepping leg's quad & glute**

 Search: "dumbbell step up exercise form"

7 Single-Leg Press

LEGS · MACHINE

Equipment: leg press machine · *(use Step-Ups instead if there's no machine)*

WHAT IT IS

A seated machine where you push a weighted platform away with one leg. It lets you load a single leg heavily with very little balance or technique demand — beginner-friendly once you're set up.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Sit in the leg press machine, back flat against the pad.
2. Place one foot centered on the platform (other foot off to the side).
3. Release the safety handles and lower the platform by bending your knee toward your chest, to about 90°.
4. Press back out through your heel — without snapping your knee straight at the top.
5. All reps on one leg, then switch.

FORM CUES

- ✓ Keep your lower back and butt flat against the seat the whole time.
- ✓ Push through your heel; control the platform on the way in.
- ✗ Don't lock your knee out hard at the top, and don't let the weight crash down.

You should feel it in the **working leg's thigh**

 Search: "single leg press machine how to" · *New to the machine? Ask a staff member to set the seat for you once.*

8 Glute Bridge

GLUTES · HAMSTRINGS

Equipment: bodyweight · optional weight resting on hips

WHAT IT IS

Lying on your back and lifting your hips by squeezing your glutes. It wakes up the exact muscles that cyclists (and desk-sitters) tend to switch off — and it's almost impossible to get wrong.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Lie on your back, knees bent, feet flat on the floor about hip-width apart.
2. Drive through your heels and lift your hips until your body forms a straight line from knees to shoulders.
3. Squeeze your glutes hard at the top and hold for one second.
4. Lower back down under control.

FORM CUES

- ✓ The lift comes from **squeezing your butt**, not from arching your lower back.
- ✓ Heels stay planted; pause and squeeze at the very top.
- ✗ Don't push your hips so high that you feel it in your lower back instead of your glutes.

You should feel it in your **glutes**

 Search: "**glute bridge proper form**"

Core — your stability & back insurance

Core work here is about **stability, not crunches**. A strong, stable core is what keeps your lower back happy through 4 hours on the bike and lets you put power down without wasting it. Most of these are "holds" — quality of tension beats reps.

9 Plank

WHOLE CORE

Equipment: none · *build from 45 sec toward 90 sec over the weeks*

WHAT IT IS

Holding a straight-body position on your forearms. Nothing moves — you're just bracing — which trains your core to do its real job: staying rigid.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Forearms on the floor, elbows directly under your shoulders.
2. Legs straight out behind you, up on your toes.
3. Make your body one straight line from head to heels.
4. Squeeze your stomach and glutes and hold for the set time, breathing normally.

FORM CUES

- ✓ Squeeze glutes and abs together; look at the floor to keep your neck neutral.
- ✗ Don't let your hips sag toward the floor.
- ✗ Don't pike your hips up into an upside-down V.

You should feel it across the **front of your core**

 Search: "how to do a plank correctly"

10 Side Plank

OBLIQUES (SIDE CORE)

Equipment: none

WHAT IT IS

A plank rotated onto one side, supported by a single forearm. It targets the sides of your core, which stabilize you side-to-side on the bike.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Lie on your side, forearm on the floor, elbow under your shoulder.
2. Stack your feet on top of each other.
3. Lift your hips so your body is one straight line, supported by your forearm and the side of your bottom foot.
4. Hold for the set time, then switch sides.

FORM CUES

- ✓ Push your hips up and slightly forward; keep your body in one line.
- ✓ **Easier version:** drop your bottom knee to the floor for support.
- ✗ Don't let your hips sag toward the floor — that's the whole exercise giving up.

You should feel it down the **side of your waist**

 Search: "**side plank form beginner**"

11 RKC Plank

WHOLE CORE · HIGH TENSION

Equipment: none · *much shorter holds: 10–20 sec*

WHAT IT IS

A regular plank cranked to maximum full-body tension. It's a harder, much shorter plank — about intensity, not endurance.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Set up exactly like a standard plank (forearms down, body straight).
2. Now squeeze *everything* as hard as you can: clench your glutes, tighten your quads, brace your abs.
3. Imagine pulling your elbows toward your toes and your toes toward your elbows — nothing actually moves, but the tension skyrockets.
4. Hold 10–20 seconds. Keep breathing.

FORM CUES

- ✓ If you can hold it as long as a normal plank, you're not squeezing hard enough.
- ✗ Don't hold your breath — short, steady breaths through the tension.

You should feel it **everywhere** — that's the point

 Search: "**RKC plank how to**"

12 Dead Bug

DEEP CORE · STABILITY

Equipment: none

WHAT IT IS

Lying on your back, moving opposite arm and leg while keeping your lower back glued to the floor. It looks easy and isn't — it teaches your core to stay stable while your limbs move, which is exactly what protects your back on the bike.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Lie on your back. Point both arms straight up at the ceiling, and lift your knees so they're bent at 90° (shins parallel to the floor). This is the "dead bug" position.
2. Press your lower back gently into the floor — and keep it pressed there the entire time.
3. Slowly lower your right arm overhead *and* straighten your left leg toward the floor at the same time.
4. Return to start, then repeat with the left arm and right leg. That's one rep each side.

FORM CUES

- ✓ The entire point is your lower back **not** lifting off the floor — go slow and only reach as far as you can hold it down.
- ✓ Breathe out as you extend your arm and leg.
- ✗ Don't rush — speed defeats the exercise.

You should feel it **deep in your stomach**

 Search: "dead bug exercise proper form"

13 Pallof Press

ANTI-ROTATION CORE

Equipment: cable machine or a resistance band

WHAT IT IS

You press a band or cable straight out from your chest while it tries to twist you sideways — and your job is to *resist* the twist. This builds the rotational stability that keeps you steady and efficient when you're driving the pedals.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Anchor a resistance band (or set a cable) at about chest height.
2. Stand side-on to it and hold the handle with both hands against your chest.
3. Step away from the anchor until the band is under tension.
4. Press your hands straight out in front of your chest. The band will try to rotate you toward the anchor — don't let it. Stay square.
5. Bring your hands back to your chest. Finish the set, then turn around and face the other way.

FORM CUES

- ✓ Resisting the twist **is** the exercise — keep your shoulders and hips square to the front.
- ✓ Brace your stomach; move slowly and with control.
- ✗ Don't stand too close to the anchor — you need constant tension for it to work.

You should feel it in the **sides of your core** fighting the rotation

 Search: "pallof press band how to"

That's all 13. Master these and the whole strength plan is just these movements repeated and progressed. First few weeks: bodyweight and light, perfect form, watch a demo for anything that feels unclear. Add weight only when the plan's rule is met — all reps, clean form, two sessions running. — Your GranFondo Whistler training plan